

Selco India is a B2C social enterprise that aims to improve the living standards of poor households in rural India, especially in Karnataka through solar energy-based interventions and low smoke cook stoves. The initiative, which was co-founded by **Harish Hande** and **Neville Williams** in 1995 and is headquartered in Bangalore, has now also set foot into offering institutional solutions to the underprivileged population of India.

With 534 employees and having catered to 350,000 Indian households since its inception, Selco India is determined to bust the myth that economically unstable people cannot afford and maintain sustainable technologies. The enterprise's first backing was received in December 1996 from **Winrock International** which released a conditional loan of \$150,000 under the **USAID Renewable energy commercialization project**. The loan was eventually paid back in 2000. Other investors who have pledged funds to the company over the two decades are **DOEN Foundation, Lemelson Foundation, and Good Energies**. With target customers as the economically underserved and the umbrella industries as Electricity, Oil & Gas, Energy, Utilities & Waste Treatment, Selco India's major competitors include ONergy, Regreen, Blue Mountain Energy, Southern Energy Management, Sigora Solar, Sigora Solar.

Initially, the organisation focussed more on the rural poor and it wasn't until **2008** that the Slum dwellers and the urban poor were identified as a potential market. When Selco first approached the poor populace, the two major problems which presented themselves as hurdles were the aversion these people had towards new technology and the absence of financial inclusion to avail it. And even though the former seemed solvable, Selco had to find a way to eradicate the latter slowly. Although the Indian government had made provisions to promote solar appliances, awareness and monetary help in the form of loans were still missing. Banks did not prefer lending to the poor simply because they had no collateral and although they had a fixed income, there always remained a chance of relocation.

This eventually let Selco enter into partnerships with banks which provided solar loans, the first one being in **2009**. The results were fruitful for all three parties with Selco being able to fulfill its mission, banks acquiring a new customer base, and the urban poor getting access to solar energy. Selco hasn't looked back ever since.

Selco currently offers four umbrella services;

1. **Basic Energy Access:** Solar home lighting, solar water heaters, solar inverters, etc
2. **Livelihoods:** DC appliances like roti rolling machines, sewing machines, milking machines, etc
3. **Institutional:** Primary health centers, digital education tools, street lights, hostel lights, etc
4. **Advisory and Training:** Mentorship for energy enterprises, practitioner inputs to policies, related research & analysis.

Selco's vision goes beyond just providing easy access to sustainable energy, it also takes upon itself to instill self-sufficiency in the minds of those who sit at the lowest layer of the social pyramid. The whole idea behind offering training and advisory services is to generate employment and indirectly also create a manforce to maintain the already installed appliances. Apart from these services, Selco also helps boost small businesses by providing them with its vast linkages, hence creating entrepreneurs out of its users. With that being said, it is assertive to predict that Selco India is all set to spread its wings to the country and create a remarkable social impact on our society.